



MSCA POSTDOCTORAL FELLOWSHIPS

MANUAL FOR EVALUATORS 2021

European Research Executive Agency

TABLE OF CONTENT

1. GENERAL ASPECTS 3

1.1.	Why this Guide	3
1.2.	Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions Postdoctoral Fellowships.....	4
1.3.	Working as an expert.....	5
1.4.	Guiding principles	7
1.5.	Proposal content and format	9
1.6.	The remote evaluation process in SEP 10	
1.7.	Compliance with deadlines	10
1.8.	Evaluation Process Overview.....	11
1.9.	What is new in the HORIZON-MSCA-PF Evaluation with respect to H2020-MSCA-IF .	12

2. INDIVIDUAL EVALUATION IN PRACTICE ..14

2.1.	The Individual Evaluation Report phase: introduction	15
2.1.1.	Steps of the IER phase in SEP: ..	15
2.1.2.	Timing of the IER phase	15
2.2.	How to proceed in SEP?.....	16
2.3.	SEP evaluation report format	16
2.4.	How to draft your IER	16
2.5.	The evaluation criteria.....	18
2.5.1.	Criterion 1: Excellence	19

2.5.2.	Criterion 2: Impact	22
2.5.3.	Criterion 3: Quality and Efficiency of the Implementation	23
2.6.	Optional secondments	24
2.7.	Optional non-academic placement ..	24
2.8.	Proposal Evaluation Form - Other questions	26
2.8.1.	Scope of the application.....	26
2.8.2.	Exceptional funding.....	26
2.8.3.	Use of human embryos (hE) and human embryonic stem cells (hESC)	26
2.8.4.	Activities excluded from funding 26	
2.8.5.	Do no significant harm (DNSH) principle	26
2.8.6.	Exclusive focus on civil applications	26
2.8.7.	Artificial Intelligence.....	27
2.9.	Overall comments box	27
2.10.	Ethics	27
2.11.	Resubmission.....	28
2.12.	Overlap with IF, ITN, COFUND and ERC	28
2.13.	Scientific misconduct.....	28
2.14.	What if?	29
2.15.	Submit the IER	29

3. CONSENSUS PHASE In Practice 30

3.1.	The Consensus phase: introduction..	31
3.1.1.	Steps of the consensus phase ...	31
3.1.2.	Timing of the consensus phase	32
3.2.	Step 1: Consensus Report	33
3.2.1.	How to proceed in SEP?	33
3.2.2.	Reaching consensus	34
3.3.	Step 2: Scoring	35
3.3.1.	How to proceed in SEP?	36
3.4.	Last steps: Quality check.....	37

4. ANNEXES 39

4.1.	MSCA-PF Assessment Grid	39
4.2.	Training and Exercises.....	39
4.3.	TIPS & HINTS	40
4.4.	GLOSSARY.....	44

1. GENERAL ASPECTS

1.1. Why this Guide

This manual provides guidance for assessing the proposals submitted in response to the call for proposals for Marie Skłodowska-Curie Postdoctoral Fellowships (HORIZON-MSCA-2021-PF).

The assessment of proposals against the evaluation criteria and requirements specified in this guide are of utmost importance as the Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions (MSCA) represent the European Union's flagship funding programme for doctoral education and postdoctoral training of researchers as part of [Horizon Europe](#).

Ultimately, your expert evaluation will affect the careers of promising researchers and the quality of European research.

1.2. Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions Postdoctoral Fellowships

The goal of the MSCA Postdoctoral Fellowships (PFs) is to enhance the creative and innovative potential of researchers holding a PhD to acquire new skills through advanced training, international [interdisciplinary](#) and inter-sectoral mobility.

MSCA PFs are open to excellent researchers of any nationality. The scheme also encourages researchers to work on research and innovation projects in the [non-academic sector](#).

The recruited [postdoctoral researchers](#) must comply with the [mobility rule](#) and have a maximum of 8 years full-time equivalent [experience in research](#) at the call deadline.

Proposals may include a [secondment](#) within the overall duration of the fellowship in any country worldwide (more info in chapter [2.6](#)).

A [non-academic placement](#) may also be included in the proposal for an additional period of up to six months **directly after the end of the fellowship**. The placement must take place in the non-academic sector in an EU Member State or Horizon Europe

Associated Country (AC) (more info in chapter [2.7](#)).

MSCA PFs are open to all fields of research and innovation, chosen freely by the [applicants](#). This also includes areas of research covered by the [Euratom](#) Research and Training Programme 2021-2025.

[Link to European Member States](#)

[Link to countries with association status in Horizon Europe](#)

Please note that Switzerland is not an associated country in the PF 2021 call and is treated as Third Country.

Applicants must indicate at the submission stage in which of the eight different scientific areas their proposal fits best. The **eight 'evaluation panels'** are: Chemistry (CHE), Social Sciences and Humanities (SOC), Economic Sciences (ECO), Information Science and Engineering (ENG), Environment and Geosciences (ENV), Life Sciences (LIF), Mathematics (MAT) and Physics (PHY).

As an evaluator, you will assess different PFs:

European Postdoctoral Fellowships (EFs)

EFs are hosted in EU Member States or Horizon Europe Associated Countries from 12 to 24 months and are open to researchers holding a PhD of any nationality either coming to Europe from any country in the world or moving within Europe.

Global Postdoctoral Fellowships (GFs)

GFs are based on a 12 to 24-month stay in a [Third Country](#) outside Europe followed by a mandatory 12-month return period to a European host institution in an EU Member State or a Horizon Europe Associated Country.

Applications are made jointly by the researcher and an institution in the academic or non-academic sector established in an EU MS or [Horizon Europe Associated Country](#).

[Euratom Fellowships:](#) Applicants who chose in the proposal to be considered for a Euratom MSCA-PF can apply either for European Postdoctoral Fellowships or Global Postdoctoral Fellowships. The proposals will be ranked in the same scientific panel ranking lists as other proposals.

You can find further information in the [MSCA Work Programme](#) and the [Guide for Applicants](#).

1.3. Working as an expert

The **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** is mandated by the European Commission to support the EU's Research and Innovation policy by funding high-quality research and innovation projects that generate knowledge for the benefit of society.

The award of MSCA PFs is through an open competition and a transparent and independent evaluation.

To assist with the evaluation of MSCA PF proposals, REA appoints external experts whose tasks differ depending on their roles:

- **Evaluators:** draft the Individual Evaluation Report (IER) and actively participate in the consensus discussion leading to the finalization of the Consensus Report (CR). One of the Evaluators of each proposal will also be asked to act as Rapporteur.
- **Rapporteurs:** after drafting their IER, they draft the Consensus Report (CR), moderate the consensus discussion, suggest a CR score, and implement

comments from the other two Evaluators in the CR.

- **Vice-Chairs:** are experienced Evaluators with in-depth knowledge of the MSCA evaluation process who assist the REA with the allocation of experts to proposals and with expert monitoring. They do not evaluate the proposals but perform a quality check of the IERs and the CRs prepared by the Evaluators and the Rapporteurs; thus, they may give feedback on the quality of the reports. Vice-Chairs monitor the timely submission of the reports and check the quality of each Evaluator's first three IERs and each Rapporteur's first three CRs. Vice-Chairs perform quality checks on all CRs after the three evaluators have reached a consensus. They are your first point of contact during the evaluation.
- The **Chair** of a panel is an expert with an in-depth knowledge of the MSCA evaluation process and therefore, together with the Vice-Chairs, assists the REA in the overall management of the evaluation process and monitoring of its progress.

Ethics Experts: perform ethics screenings for proposals on the main and reserve list after the scientific evaluation has been finalised.

- **Independent Observer:** is an independent expert appointed by the REA who follows, observes and checks the entire evaluation process and related procedures. They check compliance with the procedures stipulated in the 2021-2022 Work Programme and the [HE Online Manual](#). They report on the correct and fair implementation of the evaluation and give their suggestions for improvement, as necessary, in a report to the REA. The Observer does not express views on proposals or on other experts' opinions.
- **REA staff**, with the support of the Chair(s) and Vice-Chairs, are responsible for managing the evaluation process and monitoring its progress. They ensure that the evaluation rules are respected. They give advice to experts so as to ensure a quality and timely completion of the process.

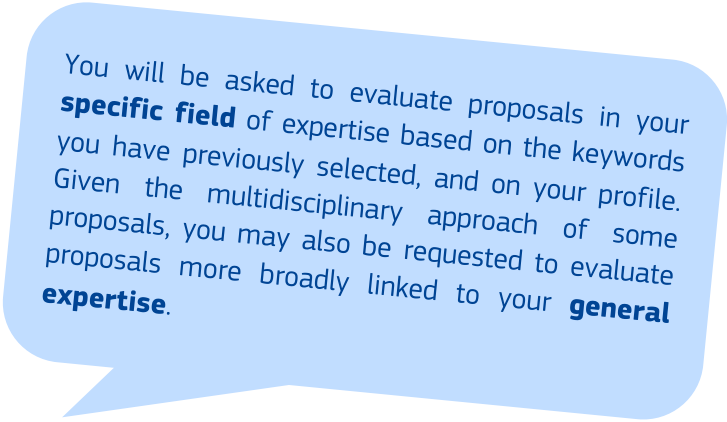
Each proposal is evaluated against a pre-defined **list of criteria** by at least three Evaluators, who are supervised by their Vice-Chair and under the umbrella of REA staff.

Volume of work: participation in the HORIZON-MSCA-PF evaluation exercise does not imply consecutive or 9-to-5 working days, but flexible working hours according to the deadlines which will be provided in due time. The number of proposals you will be asked to assess largely depends on the number of proposals received in your area of expertise. Please follow the instructions from your Vice-Chair on how to prioritise your tasks.

SEP tool: is a web-based electronic tool used for evaluating proposals. All the work of the Evaluators and Rapporteurs is performed remotely and may be carried out at your home or place of work.

For any questions related to your contracts, fees to be claimed or payments, please email the REA service responsible for that at:

rea-experts@ec.europa.eu



You will be asked to evaluate proposals in your **specific field** of expertise based on the keywords you have previously selected, and on your profile. Given the multidisciplinary approach of some proposals, you may also be requested to evaluate proposals more broadly linked to your **general expertise**.

1.4. Guiding principles

While conducting the evaluations, you are expected to comply with the following principles, as stated in **Annex 1 of the Code of Conduct of the expert contract**

1. INDEPENDENCE

You are appointed in your personal capacity and act independently and in the public interest, not in your country or employer's interest.

2. IMPARTIALITY

You treat all proposals equally and evaluate them impartially on their merits, irrespective of their origin or the identity of the applicants.

3. OBJECTIVITY

You evaluate each proposal as submitted and not based on its potential if certain changes were to be made.

4. ACCURACY

You base your judgment on the three official evaluation criteria the proposal addresses, and nothing else.

5. CONSISTENCY

You apply the same standard of judgment to all proposals.

6. CONFIDENTIALITY

- You discuss evaluation matters – such as the content of proposals, evaluation results or opinions of fellow experts evaluators – only with your fellow experts involved in evaluating the same proposal.
- Do not disclose the names of your fellow experts or your involvement in the evaluation (at the end of each year, the Commission publishes the experts' names – as a group – but no link is made between an expert and a proposal).
- You maintain the confidentiality of documents, paper or electronic, at all times and wherever you do your evaluation work and you must return, destroy or delete all confidential documents, paper or electronic, upon completing your work.

7. CONFLICT OF INTEREST (CoI) RULES

You must inform the REA as soon as you become aware of a CoI:

- before signature of the contract;
- upon receipt of proposals; or
- during the course of your work.

Please also refer to your contract and the

[briefing for experts](#) on the Funding & Tenders Portal. The REA will determine if there is a CoI on a case-by-case basis and decide the course of action to follow. You have a Conflict of Interest (CoI) if:

- You are involved in a competing proposal, or were involved in the preparation of the proposal (including pre-proposal checks);
- You could benefit directly or indirectly if a proposal is accepted or rejected;
- You have a close family or personal relationship with any person involved in the preparation of any proposal submitted to this call;
- You are a director, trustee or partner or are in any way involved in the management of an organisation involved in the preparation of any proposal submitted to this call;
- You are involved in the secondment phase or non-academic placement of a proposal;
- You are employed or contracted by one of the applicants or any named sub-contractors;
- You are a member of an advisory group set up by the Commission to advise on the preparation of Euratom or Horizon Europe Work programmes or work

plans in an area related to the call;

- You are a National Contact Point (NCP) or a person working directly for the Enterprise Europe Network (EEN);
- You are a member of a Horizon Europe Programme Committee.

On a case-by-case basis, the REA may nevertheless decide to invite an expert with a declared Col to take part in the evaluation session, while being excluded from the evaluation of the proposal(s) concerned, if all of the following applies:

- the expert works in a different team/department/laboratory/institute from where the action is to be carried out;
- the departments/laboratories/institutes within the organisation concerned operate with a high degree of autonomy;

In addition, the REA will decide whether a Col exists — taking into account the objective circumstances, available information and related risks — if an expert:

- was employed by one of the applicants in the previous three years;
- is involved in a contract or grant agreement, grant decision,

membership of management structures (e.g. member of management or advisory board etc.) or in a research collaboration with a host/partner organisation or a researcher (or had been in the last three years);

- is in any other situation that could cast doubt on their ability to participate impartially in the evaluation of the proposal (or that could reasonably appear to do so in the eyes of an external third party).

*If you knowingly hide a Col, you will be excluded from the evaluation and your work declared null and void.
Your contract will be terminated and your allowances may be reduced, rejected or recovered.
You may also be excluded from working as an Evaluator for EU research programmes in the future.*

1.5. Proposal content and format

The proposals you are asked to evaluate are composed of two parts, Part A and Part B:

- **Part A** includes administrative and financial information of the host institution (beneficiary) and the researcher, as well as information on ethics and security;
- **Part B** includes the description of scientific and training activities. It is further divided into:
 - **Part B-1** describes the aspects Excellence, Impact and Quality and Efficiency Implementation. The maximum total length of this document is **10 pages**. Any excess pages (i.e. numerical page 11 and beyond) will not be available to the evaluators.
 - **Part B-2** contains the researcher's CV, a description of the participating organisations, potentially information on ethical or security aspects and a letter of commitment (for GF and, if applicable, for non-academic placements). There is no page limit applied to Part B-2.

The structure of Part B is the following:

<u>PART B1</u>	
1 EXCELLENCE	
2 IMPACT	
3 QUALITY AND EFFICIENCY OF THE IMPLEMENTATION	10 PAGES MAX
<u>PART B2</u>	
4 CV OF THE EXPERIENCED RESEARCHER	
5 CAPACITIES OF THE PARTICIPATING ORGANISATIONS (1 page per organisation)	
6 ETHICAL ASPECTS	
7 SECURITY ASPECTS	
8 LETTER OF COMMITMENT FROM <u>ASSOCIATED PARTNERS</u> (if applicable)	
→ host for outgoing phase of GF	
→ non-academic placement host	

Proposals must also respect certain **formatting standards** described in the [Project proposal – Technical description \(Part B\)](#).

- All margins should be at least 15 mm (not including any footers or headers).
- The reference fonts for the body text of proposals are Times New Roman (Windows platforms), Times/Times

New Roman (Apple platforms) or Nimbus Roman No. 9 L (Linux distributions).

- The **minimum font size is 11 points**, except for the Gantt chart and tables where the minimum font size is 8 points. Tables are only to be used for illustrating the core text of the proposal.
- Standard character spacing and a minimum of single line spacing is to be used.

If a proposal does not comply with the formatting standards, please inform your Vice-Chair.

If confirmed, REA staff will ask applicants to reformat their proposal. This may result in excess pages, which must be disregarded in the evaluation.

1.6. The remote evaluation process in SEP

You will perform your work in SEP – the EU online tool for remote evaluation.

The web link below describes in detail how to use the SEP evaluation tool. It provides reference information about the available screens and forms, additional actions available to REA staff, and more.

Link access to SEP:

<https://ec.europa.eu/research/participants/evaluation/>

Link to SEP guidelines:

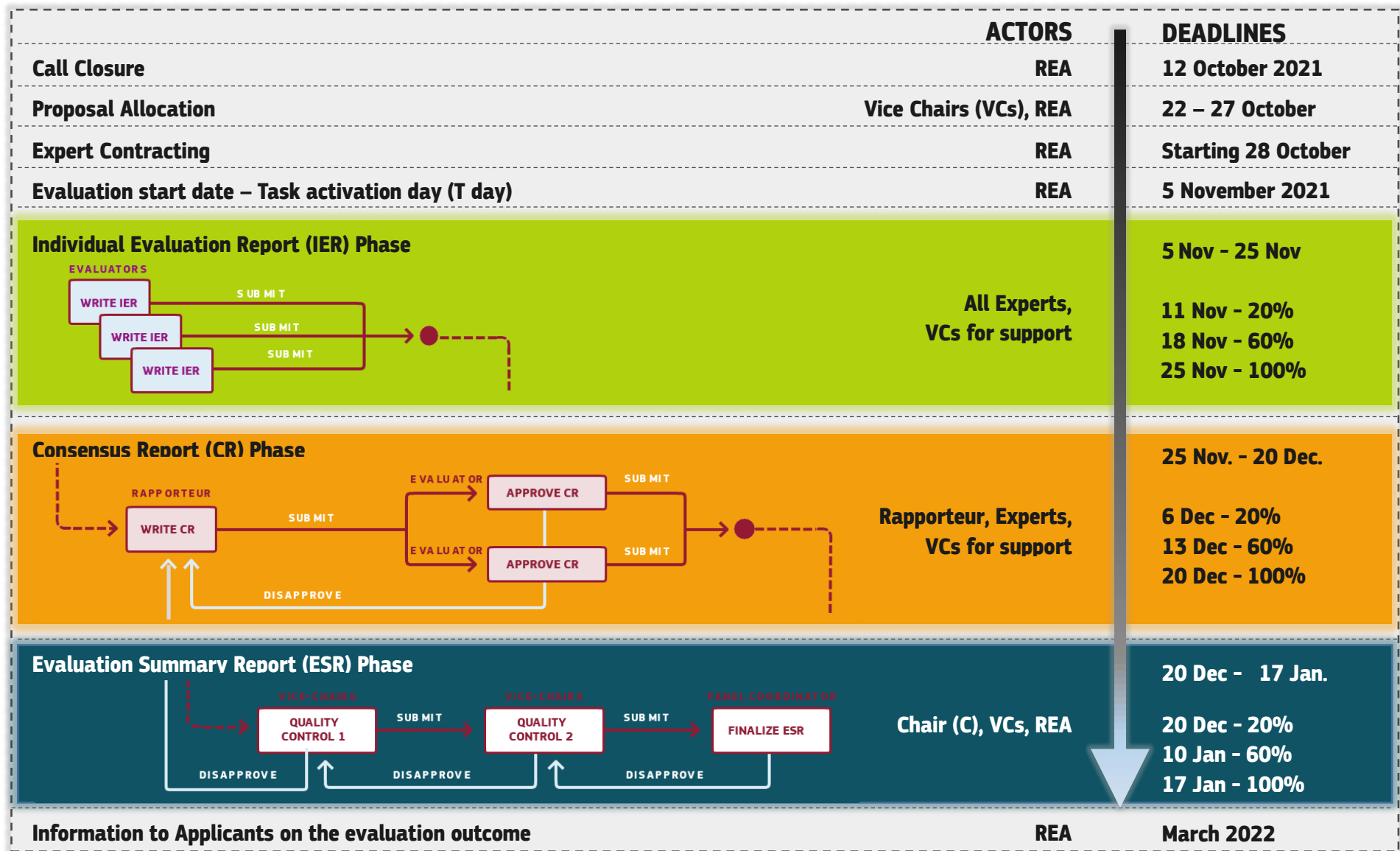
[Introduction to proposal evaluation in SEP](#)

1.7. Compliance with deadlines

Please remember that any delay on your side in delivering your work may affect other experts' work and block the whole process. Therefore, you are kindly requested to:

- Check your 'Active Tasks' in SEP on a daily basis throughout the whole remote evaluation phase;
- Be reachable: in the case of unavailability on (a) certain day(s), please let your fellow experts and/or your Vice-Chair know;
- Be proactive: the Rapporteur must monitor the progress of the CR and contact the other two experts via the comments box in SEP should delays occur.
- Remain available until the end of your contract, in case further input is required from you.

1.8. Evaluation Process Overview



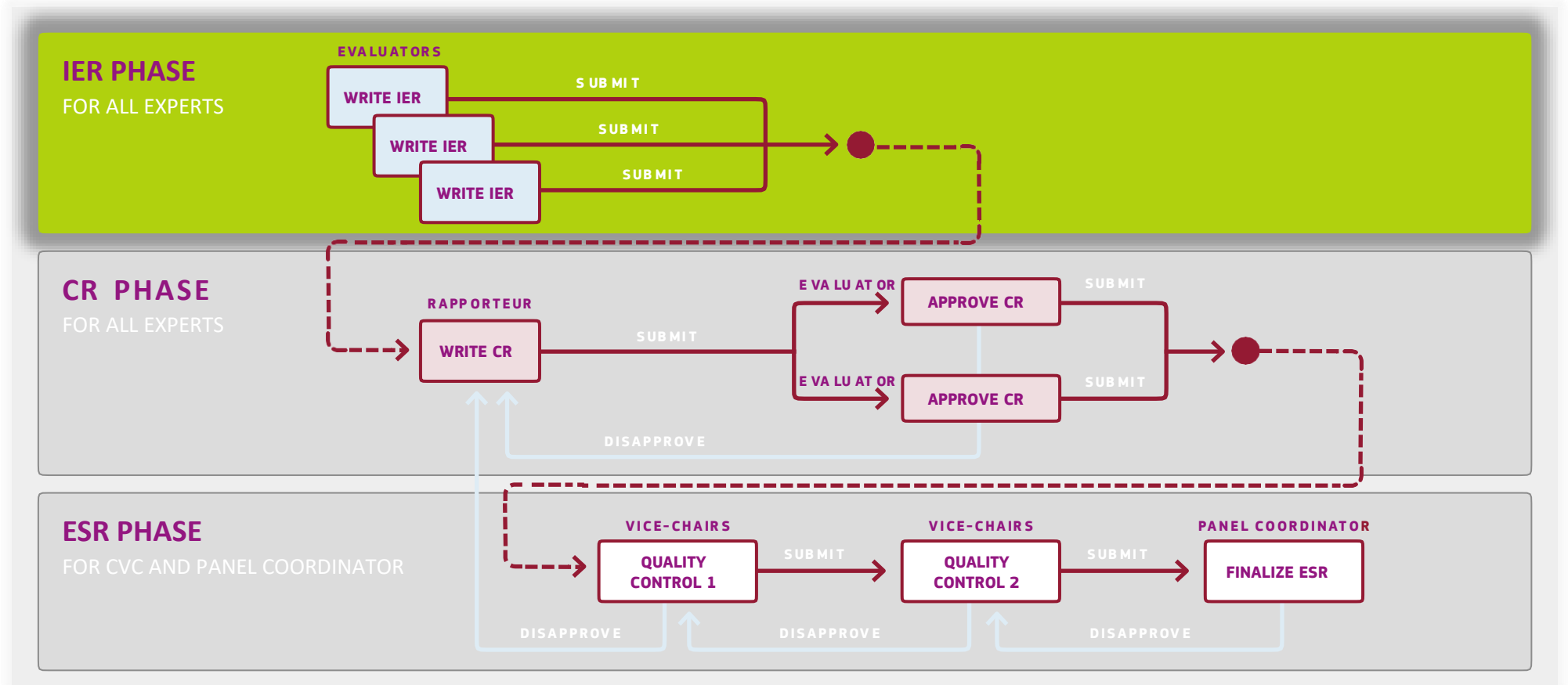
1.9. What is new in the HORIZON-MSCA-PF Evaluation with respect to H2020-MSCA-IF

1. NON ACADEMIC PLACEMENT	Possibility to add a non-academic placement (in a European non-academic organisation) at the end of the project for a maximum duration of up to 6 months (see chapter 2).
2. SECONDMENTS	New rules on duration and geographic scope (see chapter 2): → for European Fellowships up to 1/3 of the standard duration (excluding potential placement) → for Global Fellowships 1/3 of the outgoing phase, it cannot take place during the incoming phase) → it can take place worldwide
3. EVALUATION CRITERIA	NEW → Optional placement in the non-academic sector assessed under sub-criterion 1.3 and 3.2 → Open science practices to be addressed/evaluated under sub-criterion 1.2 → Sub-criterion 2.3 to assess impact on societal and economic levels, along with scientific impact Rearranged compared to H2020: → H2020 sub-criterion 1.1 : split in two parts in HE (now 1.1 and 1.2) → H2020 sub-criteria 1.2 and 1.3 merged in one in HE (now 1.3), including gender dimension → H2020 sub-criteria 2.2. and 2.3. merged in one (now 2.2) → H2020 criterion 3 sub-criteria are re-arranged and merged to become 2 sub-criteria
4. SCORING	If the score given for a criterion is below 5 , shortcoming(s) must be mentioned under this criterion in the CR. If there are no shortcomings at all, the proposal must be awarded a score of 5 for the criterion in question (see chapter 3.3).
5. OPERATIONAL CAPACITY	No separate check box anymore – to be evaluated as part of criterion 3.

6. CAR, RI, SE PANELS REMOVED	No specific panels dedicated to Career Restart, Reintegration and Society & Enterprise anymore. Any career breaks and periods spent outside Europe are part of the eligibility checks carried out by REA. Non-academic organisations can apply as beneficiaries throughout the programme.
7. RESEARCHER EXPERIENCE	Doctoral Degree (or, date of successful defence) must be obtained before call deadline. Maximum 8 years full-time equivalent experience in research from the date of award of the (first) doctoral degree.. This is part of the eligibility check performed by REA. See guide for applicants (link) for the details on how the research experience is calculated.
8. OPEN SCIENCE PRACTICES	Open science practices should be implemented as an integral part of the proposed methodology. Therefore, they must be assessed under the criterion Excellence.
9. OTHER QUESTIONS IN THE EVALUATION REPORT	Compared to the last Horizon 2020 evaluation, additional questions need to be considered in the evaluation report (see chapters 2.3 and 2.8).
10. SECURITY SELF ASSESSMENT	A mandatory security questionnaire for applicants is added to the proposals. The security screening will be performed by Commission services.
11. EURATOM	EURATOM proposals will compete within (the other) scientific panels and will be ranked together with the other proposals – as evaluators, you do not need to take any specific action.
12. ERA FELLOWSHIPS	Continuation of the former “Widening Fellowships” – as Evaluators, you do not need to take any action.

For additional information, please refer to the [MSCA Work Programme](#) and the [Guide for Applicants](#).

2. INDIVIDUAL EVALUATION IN PRACTICE



IER: Individual Evaluation Report
CR: Consensus Report
ESR: Evaluation Summary Report
CVC: Chair and Vice Chairs

2.1. The Individual Evaluation Report phase: introduction

What is an IER?

The Individual Evaluation Report (IER) is the report that Evaluators draft for each of their allocated proposals by writing a bullet-point list of strengths and weaknesses for each sub-criteria directly in SEP. IMPORTANT: No scores are given in the IER.

2.1.2. Timing of the IER phase

The aim of the IER phase

The aim is to obtain at least three IERs written by different Evaluators for each proposal. The IERs will serve as the working basis for the drafting of the Consensus Report.

The actors of the IER phase

In the IER phase, all **Evaluators** perform their tasks on their own under the

supervision and with the support of their **Vice-Chair**.

2.1.1. Steps of the IER phase in SEP:

1. **Accept** the task in SEP
2. **Draft** the IER
3. Save and **submit** the IER in SEP

Please proceed in alphabetical order with your IERs.

EVALUATION START DATE – TASK ACTIVATION DAY (T DAY)	5 November 2021
START OF IER PHASE	Accept your tasks as soon as you have access to SEP
DRAFTING IER	By 11/11/2021: 20 % of IERs submitted By 18/11/2021: 60 % of IERs submitted By 25/11/2021: 100 % of IERs submitted

2.2. How to proceed in SEP?

As soon as you have signed your contract and the evaluation start date (task activation day) has been reached or passed, you will gain access to SEP where you can see the proposal abstracts and the names of the host organisation supervisor and researcher for the proposals assigned to you. You should check that your expertise is appropriate and that you don't have a conflict of interest. If you have a Col, please decline the task ([Declining a Task](#)).

You must confirm your readiness to evaluate each proposal assigned to you in SEP ([Accepting a Task](#)) as soon as receiving access. It is important that you accept the tasks without unnecessary delay, unless you detect a Col.

2.3. SEP evaluation report format

The evaluation report is prepared in an online template in SEP. The three main parts reflect the three award criteria. In addition, experts are requested to consider additional points in subsequent sections.

The structure of the report in SEP is the following:

1 EVALUATION
1. EXCELLENCE
• strengths • weaknesses
2. IMPACT
• strengths • weaknesses
3. QUALITY AND EFFICIENCY OF THE IMPLEMENTATION
• strengths • weaknesses
2 OTHER QUESTIONS
Scope of the application
Exceptional funding
Use of human embryonic stem cells (hESC)
Use of human embryos
Activities excluded from funding
Do no significant harm principle
Exclusive focus on civil applications
Artificial Intelligence
3 OVERALL COMMENTS

2.4. How to draft your IER

As an Evaluator, you will:

- Check the type of action of the proposal (EF or GF) before assessing it,

and take into account the specific objectives of each type of action.

- Read the proposal and assess it independently:

You are invited to proceed in **alphabetical order** of the proposal acronyms (as they appear in SEP). This will allow everybody to start the following phase (consensus) in an efficient and timely manner.

- Do your assessment without discussing it with anybody else, except your Vice-Chair (if necessary).
- Evaluate it as submitted – not on its potential, if certain changes were to be made, nor by visiting websites which might be mentioned in the proposal. For example, if a proposal requires substantial modifications in terms of implementation (i.e. additional work packages), this must be reflected in a weakness under the 'Quality and Efficiency of the Implementation' criterion.

Explain shortcomings, but do not make recommendations.

- Assess the proposal against the three evaluation criteria.
- Make your comments for each criterion. Keep a bullet-point list of 'strengths and weaknesses' for each criterion (Excellence, Impact, and Quality and Efficiency of the Implementation).

A good practice is to begin by skimming through several – if not all – assigned proposals to get a general idea of the content and quality of proposals. This will allow you to identify proposals that are weak and/or missing certain elements while at the same time noticing more 'complete' (i.e. better developed) proposals. You will note that it will be easier to start writing and get the IERs right the first time without having to make corrections. This may help you to calibrate your way of assessing and formulating the strengths and weaknesses

and avoid having to reconsider some of your comments in the IER.

Please notify your VC by email once your first three IERs are in draft status so that the VC can provide feedback and advice on the quality of the reports before submission. Do not send any reports via email.

Please feel free to contact your Vice-Chair if you would like more feedback on the quality of your reports.

Please consider the whole proposal as composed of Part A and Part B. In case of conflicting information between the two parts, please contact your VC.

Be aware that applicants are required to respect a page limit of maximum 10 pages for part B-1 (Excellence, Impact and Quality and Efficiency of the implementation) to ensure equal treatment of the proposals. Excess pages of part B-1 will automatically be made invisible by SEP.

For formatting standards, please refer to [chapter 1.5](#).
If the proposal does not comply with the formatting standards, please report this to your Vice-Chair.

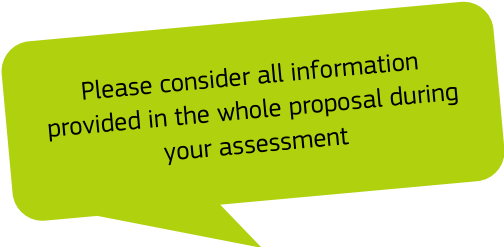
Please disregard any hyperlinks leading to information outside the proposal.

You are not asked to assign scores to the IERs.
Scores will only be given and agreed on by the 3 evaluators in the Consensus Reports

2.5. The evaluation criteria

The three main criteria are:

1. **Excellence** - weighted 50%
2. **Impact** - weighted 30%
3. **Quality and Efficiency of the Implementation** - weighted 20%



Please consider all information
provided in the whole proposal during
your assessment

2.5.1. Criterion 1: Excellence

EXCELLENCE is about:

- quality and pertinence of the R&I objectives
- soundness of the methodology
- relevance of interdisciplinary approaches, gender and diversity aspects
- quality of the planned open science practices
- quality of the supervision
- the researcher's existing professional experience;

The **gender and diversity aspects** under criterion 1.2 relate to the content of the planned activities, and not to gender balance in the teams in charge of carrying out the research.¹

Open Science and Open science practices

As an Evaluator, you should assess how appropriate **open science practices** are implemented as an integral part of the proposed methodology and how the choice of practices and their implementation are adapted to the nature of the work, in a way that will increase the chances of achieving the objectives.

EXCELLENCE SUB-CRITERIA	WHAT TO EVALUATE
1.1 QUALITY AND PERTINENCE OF THE PROJECT'S RESEARCH AND INNOVATION OBJECTIVES (AND THE EXTENT TO WHICH THEY ARE AMBITIOUS, AND GO BEYOND THE STATE OF THE ART)	→ quality and pertinence of the research and innovation objectives → extent to which the proposed work is ambitious and goes beyond the current state of the art in the field → whether research and innovation objectives are realistically achievable, measurable and verifiable
1.2 SOUNDNESS OF THE PROPOSED METHODOLOGY (INCLUDING INTERDISCIPLINARY APPROACHES, CONSIDERATION OF THE GENDER DIMENSION AND OTHER DIVERSITY ASPECTS IF RELEVANT FOR THE RESEARCH PROJECT, AND THE QUALITY OF OPEN SCIENCE PRACTICES)	→ soundness of the methodology, including the concepts, models and assumptions that underpin the project; whether important methodological challenges are identified and measures to tackle them proposed. → extent to which an interdisciplinary approach is relevant for the research; if relevant, evaluate how expertise and methods from different disciplines will be brought together and integrated; if not relevant, is this sufficiently argued in the proposal? → extent to which the gender dimension and other diversity aspects are relevant for the research; if relevant, evaluate how they are taken into account in the project's research and innovation content; if not relevant, is a proper justification provided? → how appropriate open science practices are implemented as an integral part of the proposed methodology. If not considered appropriate in the context of the proposed work, whether this is sufficiently explained and justified in the proposal;

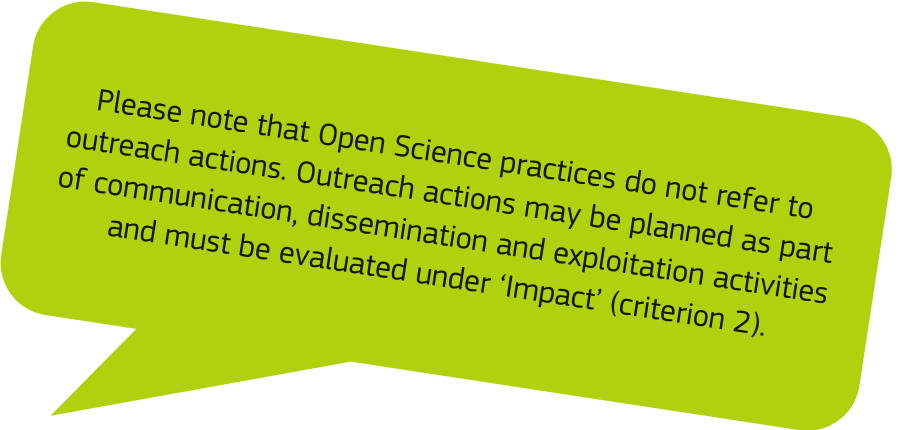
¹ For guidance on methods of sex / gender analysis and the issues to be taken into account, please refer to https://ec.europa.eu/info/news/gendered-innovations-2-2020-nov-24_en

If the proposal has appropriate justifications for not including open science practices, you should not penalise it. However, if open science practices are not sufficiently addressed, you might consider adding a shortcoming.

Please evaluate the following:

- Research output management through a **Data Management Plan** (DMP) as explained in the proposal
- **Open Access to research data** (where possible) as explained in the proposal
- If applicable, **any other open science practices** explained in the proposal

Please do **not** evaluate **Open Access to peer reviewed publications**. This remains a contractual obligation (as in Horizon 2020) and is mandatory by default.



Please note that Open Science practices do not refer to outreach actions. Outreach actions may be planned as part of communication, dissemination and exploitation activities and must be evaluated under 'Impact' (criterion 2).

Scientific supervision under criterion 1.3 is considered as a crucial element for a successful MSCA PF. Guiding, supporting, directing, advising and mentoring are key factors for researchers to pursue their career paths.

Scientific supervision arrangements should clearly define that the proposed supervisors have sufficient expertise in supervising researchers at postdoctoral level. Supervisors should have the time, knowledge, experience, expertise and commitment to be able to offer the appropriate support to the researcher and provide for the necessary progress, review and feedback procedures/mechanisms.

While the MSCA Guidelines on Supervision are non-binding, funded-projects are strongly encouraged to follow their recommendations:
<https://op.europa.eu/en/publication-detail/-/publication/bb02d56e-9b3c-11eb-b85c-01aa75ed71a1/language-en>

If a proposal includes a **non-academic placement**, its rationale and added-value must be assessed under 1.3.
 Proposals without non-academic placements are not to be penalised.

Under criterion 1.4, please take into account the information in the CV and the researcher's overall track-record in relation to their level of experience.

EXCELLENCE SUB-CRITERIA	WHAT TO EVALUATE
1.3 QUALITY OF THE SUPERVISION, TRAINING AND OF THE TWO-WAY TRANSFER OF KNOWLEDGE BETWEEN THE RESEARCHER AND THE HOST	→ quality of the supervision considering the qualifications and experience of the supervisor(s), their level of experience on the research topic proposed and their track record of work, including main international collaborations, as well as the level of experience in supervising/training especially at advanced level → effectiveness of the planned training activities for the researcher (scientific aspects, management/organisation, horizontal and key transferrable skills...?) → for European Fellowships: assess the two-way transfer of knowledge between the researcher and host organisation → for Global Fellowships: assess the three-way transfer of knowledge between the researcher, host organisation, and associated partner organisation for outgoing phase → if applicable: the rationale and added value of the non-academic placement
1.4 QUALITY AND APPROPRIATENESS OF THE RESEARCHER'S PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE, COMPETENCES AND SKILLS	→ curriculum vitae of the researcher, their professional experience, competences and skills. → quality and appropriateness of the researcher's existing professional experience in relation to the research proposal.

Planned training activities may include scientific aspects, management/organisation, horizontal and key transferrable skills, etc.

2.5.2. Criterion 2: Impact

IMPACT is about:

- The enhancement of the researcher's career perspectives and skills development expected through the proposal implementation
- Dissemination, exploitation and communication of the research
- Direct scientific, societal and economic impact of the proposal

IMPACT SUB-CRITERIA	WHAT TO EVALUATE
2.1 CREDIBILITY OF THE MEASURES TO ENHANCE THE CAREER PERSPECTIVES AND EMPLOYABILITY OF THE RESEARCHER AND CONTRIBUTION TO THEIR SKILLS DEVELOPMENT	The credibility of the measures to enhance the researcher's: → expected career perspectives inside and/or outside academia → expected skills development
2.2 SUITABILITY AND QUALITY OF THE MEASURES TO MAXIMISE EXPECTED OUTCOMES AND IMPACTS, AS SET OUT IN THE DISSEMINATION AND EXPLOITATION PLAN, INCLUDING COMMUNICATION ACTIVITIES	→ planned dissemination and exploitation activities, and the target group(s) addressed → if relevant, the strategy for the management and protection of intellectual property → planning of communication and public engagement activities (their objectives, main messages, tools and channels)
2.3 THE MAGNITUDE AND IMPORTANCE OF THE PROJECT'S CONTRIBUTION TO THE EXPECTED SCIENTIFIC, SOCIETAL AND ECONOMIC IMPACTS	→ scale and importance of the expected scientific, societal and economic impacts as they are outlined in the proposal → how the results are expected to have an impact beyond the immediate scope and duration of the proposal → credibility of the quantified estimates (magnitude and importance) of the project's contribution to the expected outcomes and impacts.

Dissemination means public disclosure of the results by appropriate means, whereas **exploitation** is the use of results, e.g. for commercial purposes or in public policymaking.

Communication measures and public engagement strategy: the aim is to inform and reach out to society and demonstrate the activities performed, and the utility and benefits the project will have for citizens.

For criterion 2.2.: the dissemination, exploitation and communication measures have to be concrete and proportionate to the scale of the project.

While you may want to see a specific number of scientific articles to be published in the proposal, do not expect a very precise and detailed plan for it, as this would be developed during the project's lifetime.

Criterion 2.3:

Magnitude: how widespread the outcomes and impacts are likely to be. For example, in terms of the size of the target group, or the proportion of that group, that should benefit over time.

Importance: the value of those benefits. For example, number of additional healthy life years; efficiency savings in energy supply, etc.

2.5.3. Criterion 3: Quality and Efficiency of the Implementation

QUALITY AND EFFICIENCY OF THE IMPLEMENTATION is about:

- Quality and effectiveness of the work plan
- Risk assessment and contingency plan
- Quality and capacity of all participating organisations, including non-scientific hosting arrangements

QUALITY AND EFFICIENCY OF THE IMPLEMENTATION SUB-CRITERIA	WHAT TO EVALUATE
3.1 QUALITY AND EFFECTIVENESS OF THE WORK PLAN, ASSESSMENT OF RISKS AND APPROPRIATENESS OF THE EFFORT ASSIGNED TO WORK PACKAGES	→ quality and effectiveness of the work plan (including deliverables and milestones) → appropriateness of the effort assigned to work packages (including timing and duration of the different work packages) → research and/or administrative risks that might endanger achievement of the objectives, and the contingency plans proposed should such risks occur → whether a Gantt Chart is included (mandatory) and whether it is consistent and complete in relation to the whole work plan (taking into account WPs, scientific deliverables, milestones, secondments and placements if applicable)
3.2 QUALITY AND CAPACITY OF THE HOST INSTITUTIONS AND PARTICIPATING ORGANISATIONS, INCLUDING HOSTING ARRANGEMENTS	→ quality of the hosting arrangements, including integration in the team/institution and support services available to the researcher → quality and capacity of participating organisations, including infrastructure, logistics, facilities → If applicable, the quality of the host arrangements and the capacity of the infrastructure/facilities of the non-academic placement host.

Risk assessment: please assess whether all possible risks associated with the project and the appropriate contingency measures have been identified, including for instance the risk of the researcher to work in an adverse social/political context (example: safety of the researcher, their family and research participants). If the risks have a severe impact on the implementation and on the project as a whole, please reflect this in the comments.

Please remember to assess the information on work packages, deliverables, milestones and secondments that is included in the text (and not only in the Gantt chart).

Under criterion 3.2, all participating organisations need to be considered. For GF, both the quality and capacity of the outgoing Third Country host and the return EU MS/AC host should be outlined.

For proposals with an non-academic placement, the placement host organization should also be assessed here.

Please take into account the information provided in Part B2–Overview of the participating organisations. If applicable, assess the involvement and tasks of any 'associated partner linked to a beneficiary'.

2.6. Optional secondments

Applicants to the MSCA PF call may include an optional **secondment** phase within the overall duration of their fellowship in **any country worldwide**.

For **European PFs**, secondments cannot exceed one third of the standard fellowship duration which is between 12-24 months (as the optional non-academic placement is not included in this figure) and should be in line with the project objectives, adding significant value and impact to the fellowship.

For example: a European PF with a duration of 24 months can propose a secondment(s) of maximum 8 months.

For **Global PFs**, optional secondments can be planned for up to one third of the outgoing phase. Secondments cannot take place during the mandatory 12 months return period to the host organisation in an EU Member State or Horizon Europe Associated Country. A secondment can also take place at the start of the action, at the beneficiary (or any other organisation mentioned in the description of the action) for a maximum of 3 months (to be included

within the 1/3 maximum duration), before going to the associated partner for the outgoing phase.

- When proposed periods of secondment exceed the maximum duration allowed - you should evaluate how the proposal would be affected if the activities associated with the secondment were to be carried out within the allowed maximum duration and assess it accordingly. If necessary, you may penalise the proposal under the most appropriate criterion.
- When secondments are not in line with the project objectives and lack relevance and added-value, you should (upon your own judgment) reflect this in the comments and scores under the most appropriate criterion.

Proposals should not be penalised for not including an optional secondment or non-academic placement period.

2.7. Optional non-academic placement

Postdoctoral Fellowships proposals can include an additional (optional) period of up to six months to support researchers seeking a **placement at the end of the project** to work on R&I projects in an organisation from the **non-academic sector** established in an EU Member State or Horizon Europe Associated Country. While this possibility is also available to researchers recruited in a non-academic sector beneficiary, such a placement must be implemented at a different non-academic host organisation established in an EU Member State or Horizon Europe Associated Country. The request for such a placement must be an integral part of the proposal, explaining the added-value for the project and for the career development of the researcher, and will be subject to evaluation. It must be substantiated by a **letter of commitment** from the non-academic organisation where the placement will take place.

- When placements are not properly described or lack relevance or added-value for the project and for the career prospects of the researcher, you should reflect this in the comments and scores

accordingly under the criterion **Excellence** (1.3).

- The quality of the host arrangements and the capacity of the infrastructure/facilities of the non-academic placement host should be evaluated under the criterion **Quality and Efficiency of the Implementation** (3.2). If the Letter of Commitment does not fulfil the minimum requirements indicated in section 8 of the [Technical description \(Part B\)](#) you may penalise the proposal under criterion 3.2.

If the optional placement indicated in the proposal does not meet the requirements, i.e. **missing letter of commitment, taking place in an academic organisation or in a Third Country**:

- evaluate the proposal without taking into account the placement
- if necessary, reflect this in a weakness under the respective criterion, it may then affect the final score.

normal duration of the project) please contact your VC and REA staff.

In case of **doubt on the sector of the placement organisation** (e.g. hospital, museum), please take the placement into account and evaluate the proposal considering that the organisation belongs to the non-academic sector.

Please add a comment in the **Overall comments** box in SEP if:

- there is no letter of commitment,
- there is a letter of commitment from an organisation in a Third Country
- you have doubts on the sector of the placement organisation (academic/non-academic).

You can find the specific comments to add in [chapter 2.9](#)

For any other possible cases of non-compliance (e.g. placement during the

2.8. Proposal Evaluation Form - Other questions

In addition to the section 1. *Evaluation* to be filled in SEP, a series of questions must be addressed in section 2. *Other questions*. The answers to most of these questions are not part of the evaluation criteria above and should not feed into the strengths and weaknesses. They provide, however, important information for eligibility or subsequent evaluation steps (e.g. ethics evaluation, security scrutiny).

One exception is the [technical robustness](#) of AI-based systems, which should be evaluated under Excellence.

2.8.1. Scope of the application

Please choose “in scope” by default. MSCA PF is a bottom up programme and any topic can be funded. If a proposal is not a research proposal, please contact your Vice-Chair who will discuss with REA whether or not the proposal is out of scope.

2.8.2. Exceptional funding

This does not apply to the MSCA PF call. Please do not leave any comment in the Proposal Evaluation Form in SEP.

2.8.3. Use of human embryos (hE) and human embryonic stem cells (hESC)

If the proposal involves hE or hESC, you must state in the respective boxes whether their use is or is not necessary to achieve the scientific objectives of the proposal, and the reasons why. Alternatively, please state if this cannot be assessed due to a lack of information. Your answers and comments will be used by the ethics experts in charge of the ethics assessment.

IMPORTANT: Proposals from the main list involving hEs and/or hESC can be funded only if their use is necessary to achieve the proposal objectives.

2.8.4. Activities excluded from funding

Activities that:

- aim at human cloning for reproductive purposes, or
- intend to modify the genetic heritage of human beings which could make such changes heritable (with the exception of research relating to cancer treatment of the gonads, which may be financed), or

- intend to create human embryos solely for the purpose of research or for the purpose of stem cell procurement, including by means of somatic cell nuclear transfer, or
 - lead to the destruction of human embryos (for example, for obtaining stem cells)
- are excluded from funding.

Indicate under the subsection ‘*Activities excluded from funding*’ whether the proposal includes any of these activities.

In case the proposal includes any of these activities, please immediately alert your VC and REA staff.

2.8.5. Do no significant harm (DNSH) principle

This does not apply to the MSCA PF call. Please tick the box “not applicable” in the Proposal Evaluation Form.

2.8.6. Exclusive focus on civil applications

Indicate under the subsection ‘*Exclusive focus on civil applications*’ whether the activities proposed have an exclusive focus

on civil applications (activities intended to be used in military application or which aim to serve military purposes cannot be funded).

In case the proposal includes any such activities, please immediately alert your VC and REA staff.

2.8.7. Artificial Intelligence

Indicate here whether the activities proposed involve the use and/or development of AI-based systems and/or techniques.

If you answer 'yes' to this question, you must assess the technical robustness of the proposed AI-system as part of the Excellence criterion (if applicable).

2.9. Overall comments box

The Overall Comments box should only be used in case of excess pages and if the optional non-academic placement does not meet the requirements.

If the proposal **exceeds the page limit**, please insert the following remark:

Part B1 of this proposal exceeds the page limit. As indicated in the Guide for Applicants, the parts of the proposal exceeding the page limit have been disregarded.

If the optional **non-academic placement does not meet the requirements**, please add the following comment, depending on the situation:

→ **no letter of commitment:**

The proposal does not include a letter of commitment for the non-academic organisation for the placement; the experts evaluated the proposal without taking into consideration the contribution of the organisation without the letter of commitment.

→ **letter of commitment from an organisation from Third Country/academic sector**

The experts evaluated the proposal without taking into consideration the contribution of the organisation for non-academic placement as it is not eligible (not from an EU Member State or Horizon Europe Associated Country/not from the non-academic sector).

→ **Doubts on the sector (academic/non-academic)**

If proposed for funding, the eligibility of the non-academic placement and its implementation must be confirmed by the REA during Grant Agreement Preparation.

For any other possible cases of non-compliant placements (e.g. placement during the normal duration of the project) please contact your VC and REA staff.

2.10. Ethics

After the scientific evaluation, proposals on the funding list or close to the funding range will be screened by ethics experts. This means that:

- you DO NOT screen the proposal for ethical issues;
- comments related to ethics will not be included in the scientific evaluation reports (both individual and consensus), except if the research involves human embryonic stem cells (hESCs) and/or human embryos (HEs), when your opinion on their use is requested;
- a proposal cannot be penalised on ethical grounds. However, the ethics section may include valuable

information on the methodology and risks (e.g. safety of the researcher, their family and research participants). Scientific Evaluators might use this for their assessment of risk.

2.11. Resubmission

Proposals submitted under the last H2020 call will not be treated as resubmissions under Horizon Europe calls. This means that there will be, by definition, no resubmissions for this year's call.

2.12.Overlap with IF, ITN, COFUND and ERC

The researcher's involvement in another running EU-funded grant should not influence your evaluation.

2.13.Scientific misconduct

Any suspicion of fabrication, falsification, plagiarism or other scientific misconduct must be reported to your Vice-Chair.

2.14. What if?

IF A PROPOSAL ...

- **seems incomplete**, please inform your Vice-Chair as soon as possible, as it may be considered inadmissible.
- is difficult to read because of a **small font size** or any other reason, please inform your Vice-Chair as soon as possible. Depending on the issues identified, REA may ask the applicant to reformat their proposal to meet the standard criteria such as using an 11pt font size.
- is a **Global Fellowship that does not include a letter of commitment** from the partner organisation, it will be declared inadmissible. Please inform your Vice-Chair as soon as possible.
- is **potentially ineligible**, please continue evaluating it anyway and inform your Vice-Chair. The eligibility of the proposal is checked by REA staff during the evaluation process. In case you find elements indicating possible ineligibility (e.g. no mobility, no PhD, more than 8 years full-time research experience), your Vice-Chair will

discuss this with REA staff.

proposal.

If you want to find out more about the eligibility criteria for the different actions, please consult the [Horizon Europe MSCA Work Programme 2021-2022](#) and the [Guide for Applicants 2021](#)

2.15. Submit the IER

When your first three IERs are ready in SEP, and before submitting them in the system, please notify your Vice-Chair by e-mail. Do not send any documents/reports by email!

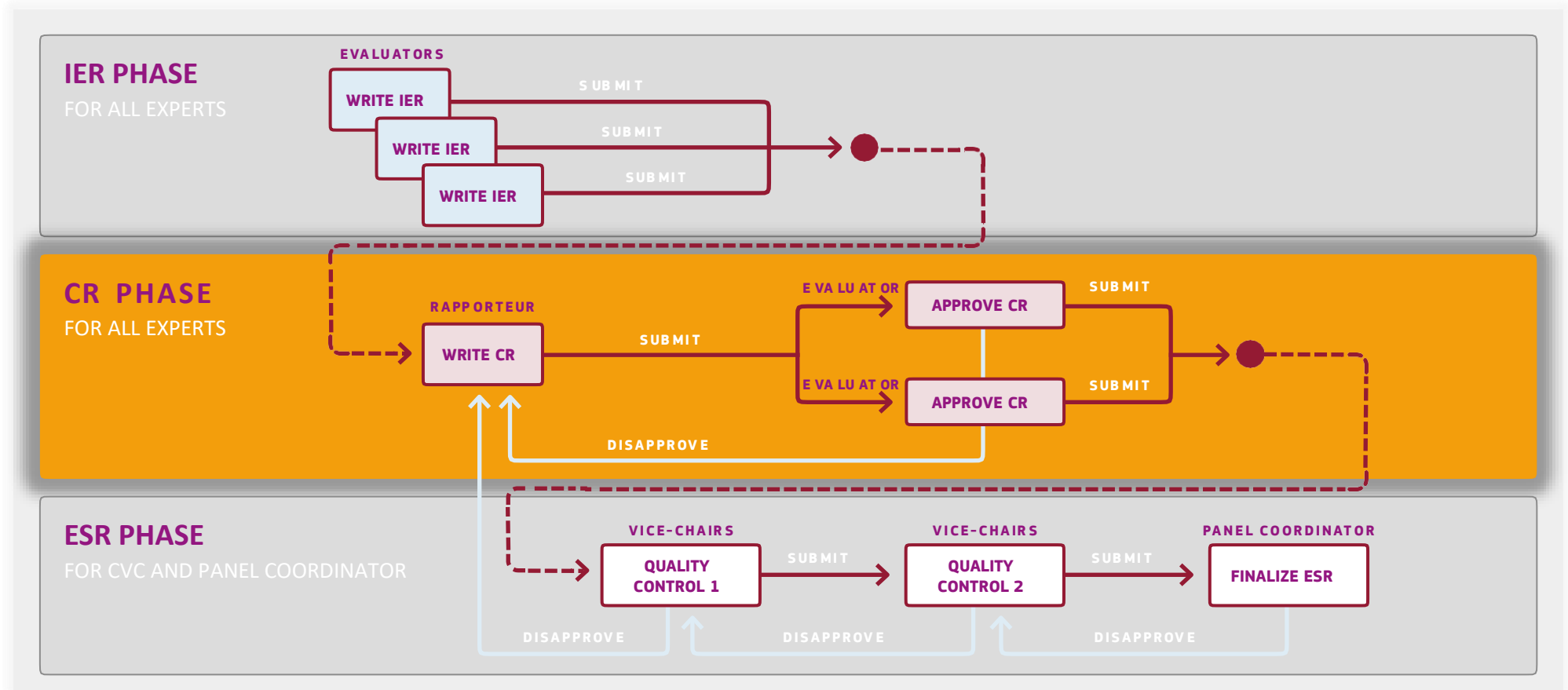
Your Vice-Chair will then give you feedback via the SEP comment box on formulating the comments and the style.

If you have submitted your Individual Evaluation Report by mistake and/or wish to reopen it, please contact your Vice-Chair.

When you are satisfied with the IER, please submit it in SEP. As soon as the two fellow Evaluators submit their IERs for the same proposal, the Consensus phase opens for this

Please remember that the CR phase can only start when all three IERs for any given proposal are submitted. Any delay on your side in delivering your work may slow down the whole process.

3. CONSENSUS PHASE IN PRACTICE



IER : Individual Evaluation Report **CR**: Consensus Report **ESR**: Evaluation Summary Report **CVC**: Chair and Vice Chairs

3.1. The Consensus phase: introduction

What is the consensus phase?

Once all three Evaluators have submitted the three IERs of a proposal in SEP, the consensus phase opens. During this phase, the three experts involved in this proposal's evaluation discuss and agree on its final Consensus Report (CR) and score. Both elements (CR and score) will lead to the Evaluation Summary Report (ESR) and the last phase of the evaluation.

The consensus phase is conducted in SEP through the discussion box and/or the teleconference facilities.

[Completing a consensus report \(CR\)](#)

[Completing a Consensus Report Using WebEx - Teleconferences](#)

The actors of the Consensus Phase:

Rapporteur

Among the three evaluators assigned to each proposal, one will receive the role of "Rapporteur".

As Rapporteur, your role is to draft the Consensus Report (CR), propose scores for each criterion, and lead the discussions with the other two Evaluators during the consensus phase.

Evaluators

As Evaluator, your role is to participate actively in the consensus discussions with the objective to reach a consensus on the text and scores and approve the CR.

Vice-chairs

The role of the Vice-chairs is to supervise and monitor this phase, and if needed to provide help to the group to reach a consensus.

The aim of the consensus phase

... is to give:

- a clear assessment of the proposal based on its merit, with examples;
- clear feedback on the proposal's strengths and weaknesses, of an adequate length, and in an appropriate tone;
- an explanation of the shortcomings, but without making recommendations;
- scores consistent with the identified strengths and weaknesses.

The quality of the CR is crucial, because the text will be included as it stands in the Evaluation Summary Report, which is sent to the applicant. Feedback to applicants must give a clear and fair assessment of the proposal based on its strengths and weaknesses in a manner consistent with the scores.

3.1.1. Steps of the consensus phase

The consensus phase is composed of two steps:

1. **Consensus on comments** (Consensus Report)
2. **Consensus on scores** (Scoring).

If a consensus is difficult to reach, the Vice-Chair may act as a facilitator to help the group reach consensus while keeping iterations in the draft CR to a minimum.

3.1.2. Timing of the consensus phase

START OF CR PHASE	The CR phase will be activated in the system on 25/11/2021
WRITE CR TASK (ONLY RAPPORTEURS)	As soon as you receive the task in SEP
APPROVE CR TASK (ONLY EVALUATORS)	As soon as you reached consensus on text and scoring
PROVISIONAL DEADLINES	By 06/12/2021 : 20 % of CRs approved By 13/12/2021 : 60 % of CRs approved By 20/12/2021 : 100 % of CRs approved

3.2. Step 1: Consensus Report

The starting points are the three Individual Evaluation Reports prepared by the three Evaluators.

These three IERs have the same weight and neither the Rapporteur nor the Evaluators should try to impose their views.

3.2.1. How to proceed in SEP?

SEP offers the option to combine the three IERs in one document. This feature is available to the Rapporteur as well as to the two Evaluators for a better overview.

Rapporteur

Once all Individual Evaluation Reports (IERs) are submitted, a Write Consensus Report (CR) task is created for you in SEP (see also [Completing a Consensus Report CR](#)).

Once accepted, you can start working on this phase.

As Rapporteur, you can use the SEP merging option to merge the IERs of the three experts in one document (Initialize/Merge reports).

You are supposed to draft the CR by

organizing and synthesizing the comments for each sub-criterion as follows:

- ☐ **STRENGTHS** (i.e. strong points that all three experts agree upon - with no repetition!).
- ☐ **WEAKNESSES** (i.e. weak points that all three experts agree upon - with no repetition!).
- ☐ Divergences in comments, etc.
→ **POINTS FOR DISCUSSION IN SEP**

It is highly recommended to use the assessment grid to ensure that all sub-criteria have been covered.

As Rapporteur, you will:

- compare comments, both within the criterion and between different criteria, in order to eliminate possible contradictions.
- ensure that the same weakness or

strength is not mentioned under different criteria.

In this process, it is helpful to number strengths/weaknesses to facilitate the consensus discussion. This numbering must be replaced by a bullet-point structure in the final consensus report.

You are invited to inform your VC via email once your first three draft CRs are ready, so that the VC can provide advice on their quality.

Once you have prepared the draft CR, you should send a notification to the two Evaluators through the comment box: "Please send me your comments based on the draft CR".

Evaluators

As Evaluator, you start reviewing the draft Consensus Report in SEP, after having been contacted by the Rapporteur via the comment box and comment on the points for discussion.

If in doubt about this process, please contact your Vice-Chair

3.2.2. Reaching consensus

The consensus phase involves a discussion based on the three IERs and an exchange of views based on the synthesis carried out by the Rapporteur (draft CR) of the individual evaluations.

A consensus is a collaborative and cooperative process where the group of experts is committed to find the solution that best reflects the opinion of the group.

Rapporteur

As Rapporteur, you will:

- identify agreements in the IERs and propose comments acceptable to all experts involved;
- identify divergences in the IERs and exchange views remotely with the other Evaluators on these points using the comment text box in SEP;
- facilitate the discussion and encourage openness;
- reach an agreement with the two other Evaluators on the draft CR;
- clarify any difference of opinion, contradiction or lack of clarity;

In case of very different views, please try to understand where the major disagreements are and prepare a focused remote consensus discussion.

Diverging opinions must be explored as they might be as valid as others: be open-minded. It is normal for individual views to change during the process.

In case a CR requires a group discussion, as a Rapporteur you can set up virtual meetings with the two evaluators via SEP:

[Completing a Consensus Report Using WebEx - Teleconferences](#)

The Vice-Chair and REA staff can also be invited to this Consensus discussion if deemed necessary.

Evaluators

As Evaluator, your active and constructive involvement in the consensus discussion is compulsory.

You are supposed to

- **react promptly** to questions or requests through SEP;
- consider the opinions of others;
- contribute to understanding and solving diverging views;
- reach agreement.

Rapporteur

Before moving to the scoring step, please make sure that in the final consensus report:

- numbering of strengths and weaknesses are replaced by bullet-points;
- the comments express strengths and weaknesses and no proposal descriptions or citations;
- all weaknesses are well justified;
- the comments are concise and clear;
- there is no scientific 'advice' or recommendations for improving the proposal;
- gender, name, nationality (etc.) of the applicant is not mentioned;
- there are NO negative remarks as regards individuals, places, nationalities, cultures or countries;
- there are NO overall remarks except for the standard sentences for excess pages issues;
- there are no references to previous evaluations.

During and after the consensus phase, the Vice-Chair will check the fairness, objectivity and accuracy of the report and will make sure the process respects all applicable rules.

For tips and hints on the quality of the consensus report, please consult the Annex.

3.3. Step 2: Scoring

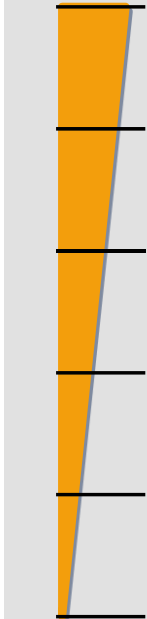
As Rapporteur and Evaluators, after agreeing on the comments, you are supposed to agree together on the scores for the three criteria: **Excellence**, **Impact** and **Quality and Efficiency of the Implementation**.

The proposal's overall score will be automatically calculated according to the weighting of the three evaluation criteria:

EVALUATION CRITERION	WEIGHT
EXCELLENCE	50 %
IMPACT	30 %
IMPLEMENTATION	20 %

The Rapporteur and Evaluators agree upon a score (from 0 to 5 – using **one decimal**) for each evaluation criterion according to the following table. The full range of scores must be used with decimals (e.g. 3.3, 4.6, 4.9 etc).

0

EXCELLENT The proposal successfully addresses all relevant aspects of the criterion. Any shortcomings are minor.	5		Excellent
VERY GOOD The proposal addresses the criterion very well, but a small number of shortcomings are present.	4		Very Good
GOOD The proposal addresses the criterion well, but a number of shortcomings are present.	3		Good
FAIR The proposal broadly addresses the criterion, but there are significant weaknesses.	2		Fair
POOR The criterion is inadequately addressed, or there are serious inherent weaknesses.	1		Poor
The proposal FAILS to address the criterion or cannot be assessed due to missing or incomplete information.	0		Fail

It is important that the scores reflect the comments (both strengths and weaknesses) agreed in the draft Consensus Report.

Please note: If the score given for a criterion is below 5, shortcoming(s) **must** be mentioned under this criterion in the CR. If there are no shortcomings at all, then the proposal must be awarded a score of **5** for the criterion in question.

3.3.1. How to proceed in SEP?

Rapporteur

The rapporteur suggests a score that best reflects the agreed comments for each criterion in the draft Consensus Report. The rapporteur sends a notification to the two Evaluators through the comment box: “Please send me your comments on the suggested scores”.

Evaluators

You receive the proposed scores through the comment box and provide comments on these. The discussion continues until an agreement is reached and the scores are coherent with the comments.

Rapporteur

After all Evaluators agreed with the scores in the comment box, you submit the CR in SEP for the approval.

If an Evaluator is not responsive, please notify the VC and/or submit the CR with a tentative score.

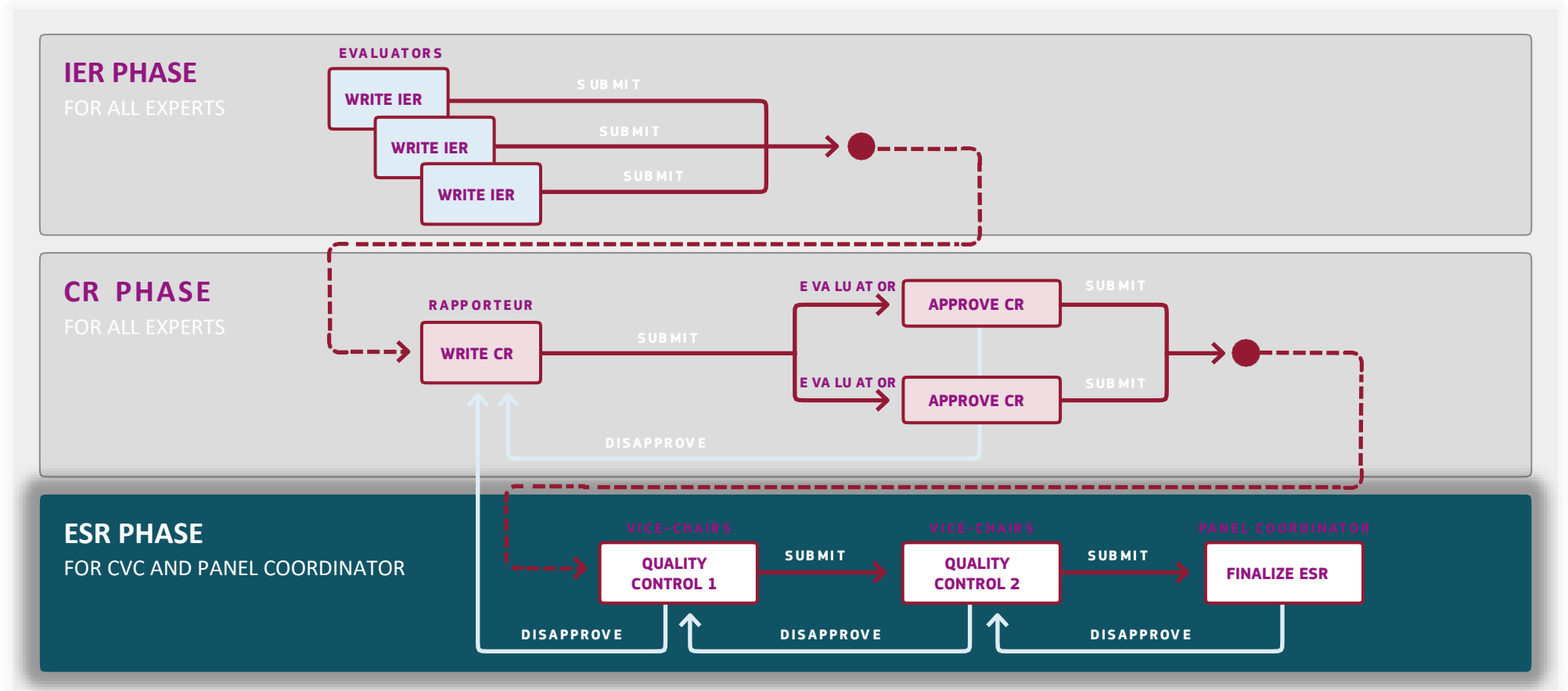
Evaluators

You receive the “approve CR” task for a final check. Either “approve” the CR, or

“disapprove” it, leaving a comment in the CR discussion comment box with the reasons.

Only after the CR is approved by all three actors (Rapporteur and two Evaluators), will the Vice-Chair receive a “draft ESR” task in SEP and perform a quality check.

3.4. Last steps: Quality check



IER : Individual Evaluation Report **CR**: Consensus Report **ESR**: Evaluation Summary Report **CVC**: Chair and Vice Chairs

During the quality check carried out by the VC, it is possible that the “draft ESR” is sent back to the Consensus phase for revision. In case this happens, as Rapporteur you should revise the CR by taking into account the comments from the VC and restart the consensus process with the other two Evaluators.



4. ANNEXES

4.1. MSCA-PF Assessment Grid

It is recommended to use the assessment grid to ensure that all sub-criteria have been covered and all additional questions have been considered correctly.

You can download the interactive assessment grid from the SEP dashboard. For this, please make sure that you are correctly in the evaluation session of this HORIZON-MSCA-2021-PF call.

4.2. Training and Exercises

REA will provide information on the availability of e-learning modules and exercises for experts and Vice Chairs.

4.3. TIPS & HINTS

DOs

The comments must be:

- Relative to the proposal as it stands;
- Specific to the relevant criterion addressing each sub-criterion;
- In light of the type of action (EF or GF);
- Clear, substantial and concise;
- Consistent with the score awarded, which must reflect strengths and weaknesses.

Examples of positive qualifiers

Very relevant, credible, very clear, precisely specified, realistic, very innovative, very well suited, timely, convincing, comprehensive, high quality, justified, very well identified, strong, highly effective, thoughtful, very promising, evidence, well-formulated, carefully prepared, fully in line, very profound, sound, very convincingly integrated, clearly articulated, coherent, well balanced, very plausible, ambitious, clear advances, well above average.

Examples of negative qualifiers

Insufficient, minimal, inadequate, very generic, not evident, unfocused, very weak, inappropriate, limited, unclear, not sound enough, not specified, no significant impact, unjustified, overestimated, unconvincing.

Examples of appropriate comments

- *There are numerous statements, which are not sufficiently grounded on [relevant research results].*
- *... is not relevant to the goals of the project because it fails to properly address issue A but instead dedicates the majority of its efforts to B.*
- *The proposal addresses well [yyy] and [zzz], because...*
- *The proposal does not fully consider...*
- *This proposal fails to properly address... / does not take [xxx] into account.*
- *The proposal lacks a clear identification of [xxx].*
- *The approach [xxx] is unlikely to enable [xxx]*

- *The proposal does not address in sufficient detail... [xxx]*
- *[xxx activities] are not described with a sufficient level of detail.*
- *...does not meet the requirement of [xxx]*

DON'Ts

The comments must not be:

- A **summary** of the proposal;
- Too short, too long, inappropriate, discriminatory, politically incorrect;
- **Categorical/general statements, not properly verified**, such as “it is missing” or “it is not provided” or “not present” or “there is no material covering ...” Instead, use “not clear”, “inadequate description”, “not well justified”, etc.
- Based on **assumptions**: if the proposal is unclear on important aspects, this should be reflected in the comments and scores;
- **Recommendations** or advice on improving the proposal;
- **Contradictory statements** relative to strengths and weaknesses (either under the same or different criteria);
- About the **same weakness or strength** under different criteria (no double penalization).

The comments must not include:

- **Real names** of institution, researchers and supervisors. Use general terms as “**host institution**”, “**researcher**” and “**supervisor**” instead;
- **The terms** “candidate”, “principal investigator” and “fellow”. Use “**the researcher**”;
- Details that could easily lead to a **factual mistake**, e.g. page numbers, amounts, years of experience, etc.
- The terms “the proposed project”. Use “**the proposal**” instead.
- **Ethical issues**, except if the research involves human embryonic stem cells (hESCs) and/or human embryos (HEs);
- **Offensive terms** (awful, terrible, dreadful)

The comments must not refer to:

- The **type of action** (EF, GF). However, for GF it is fine to refer to outgoing/incoming phase;
- **Open access (OA) to peer-reviewed publications** under strengths or

weaknesses as it is a contractual obligation;

- The **budget or financial management** – EU Contribution comes as a lump sum;

To be avoided:

- The expression “**is described**”. Such a phrase is not suitable. You need to explain whether something is ‘fully’ or ‘poorly’ described, etc.

Special attention must be paid to the use of ‘**adequate**’: it does not express a strength but simply means ‘sufficient’.

Examples of good vs. poor comments

POOR COMMENTS MERELY ECHO THE SCORE <i>The innovative aspects of the proposed research are poor.</i>	GOOD COMMENTS EXPLAIN IT <i>This proposal is not convincingly innovative in X and it does not properly take [xxx] into account.</i>
POOR COMMENTS ARE AMBIGUOUS <i>The resources for the project are unrealistic.</i>	GOOD COMMENTS ARE CLEAR <i>The project is overambitious, given the complexity of the activity proposed and the duration of the proposed work.</i>
POOR COMMENTS ARE VAGUE AND SUBJECT TO INTERPRETATION <i>We think the management is probably inadequate.</i>	GOOD COMMENTS ARE PRECISE AND FINAL <i>The management plan is inadequate. It does not include a clear description of overall responsibility for the activities; it also lacks a proper risk management plan.</i>
POOR COMMENTS ARE INACCURATE AND PROVIDE AN OPENING FOR A COMPLAINT <i>There is no discussion of a dissemination strategy. The supervisor is not experienced.</i>	GOOD COMMENTS CLOSE THE QUESTION <i>The proposal fails to address the dissemination strategy at the appropriate level of detail.</i> <i>The supervisor does not demonstrate the necessary level of experience in this field.</i>
POOR COMMENTS INCLUDE WORDS LIKE <i>Perhaps, think, seems, assume, probably ...</i>	GOOD COMMENTS INCLUDE WORDS LIKE <i>Because, specifically, for example ...</i>

A real example of inconsistency between scores and comments:

EXCELLENCE CRITERION : SCORE 4.5

STRENGTHS:

- The objectives of the research project are **well presented** and **clearly** structured.
- The project is original and the state of the art **is sufficiently presented**.
- The partners have complementary expertise that **is beneficial** to the project.

WEAKNESSES:

- The methodology for the project is **not fully convincing**.
- The data-collection strategy, potential sources of information and data accessibility are **unclear**.
- The proposal fails **to sufficiently demonstrate** that the beneficiary has the necessary expertise and capabilities to obtain the necessary information for the project.

In this case, the strengths include words like 'well presented', 'clear', 'sufficient' and 'beneficial', i.e. nothing pointing towards excellent. At the same time, there are obvious weaknesses. However, the score given was 4.5, i.e. between 'very good' and 'excellent', which is not consistent with the comments when they are all taken into consideration.

4.4. GLOSSARY

AC: Horizon Europe Associated Country: A country associated to Horizon Europe ([link](#))

Academic sector: public or private higher education establishments awarding academic degrees, public or private non-profit research organisations and International European Research Organisations (IERO).

Applicant: the host research organisation (including the supervisor(s)) and the researcher.

Associated partner: entity that contributes to the implementation of the action, but do not sign the grant agreement.

Associated partner hosting the outgoing phase: for GF only. It is a single independent legal entity established in a non-associated Third Country.

Beneficiary: legal entity that signs the grant agreement (either directly or through an accession form) and has the responsibility for the proper implementation of the action. They contribute directly to the implementation of the research, transfer of

knowledge and training activities. In the case of the Postdoctoral Fellowships call, this involves recruiting, supervising, hosting, training and, where appropriate, seconding the researcher.

EF: European Postdoctoral Fellowships.

EURATOM (European Atomic Energy Community): organisations active in nuclear research established in one of EU Member States or countries associated to the Euratom Research and Training programme 2021-2025, are eligible to participate.

GfA: Guide for Applicants ([link](#))

GF: Global postdoctoral fellowship

Interdisciplinarity: integration of information, data, techniques, tools, perspectives, concepts or theories from two or more scientific disciplines.

Mobility rule: the recruited researcher must not have resided or carried out their main activity (work, studies, etc.) in the country of the beneficiary (for European Postdoctoral Fellowships), or the host organisation for the outgoing phase (for Global Postdoctoral Fellowships) for more

than 12 months in the 36 months immediately before the call deadline. Researchers wishing to reintegrate from a Third Country either must be based in a Third Country at the call deadline, or have moved directly from a Third Country to an EU Member State or Horizon Europe Associated Country within the last 12 months before the call deadline. For 'International European Research Organisations' (IERO), 'international organisations', or entities created under Union law, the researchers must not have spent more than 12 months in the 36 months immediately before the call deadline, in the same appointing organisation. Compulsory national service, short stays such as holidays and time spent as part of a procedure for obtaining refugee status under the Geneva Convention are not taken into account.

MS: EU Member States

MSCA: Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions

Non-academic placement: additional period of up to six months directly after the end of the fellowship in the non-academic sector. It can take place in EU Member States or Horizon Europe associated countries.

Non-academic sector: any socio-

economic actor not included in the academic sector and fulfilling the requirements of the Horizon Europe (HE) Rules for Participation.

Open Science: Open science is an approach based on open cooperative work and systematic sharing of knowledge and tools as early and widely as possible in the process.

Open science practices: include early and open sharing of research (for example through preregistration, registered reports, pre-prints, or crowd-sourcing); research output management; measures to ensure reproducibility of research outputs; providing open access to research outputs (such as publications, data, software, models, algorithms, and workflows); participation in open peer-review; and involving all relevant knowledge actors including citizens, civil society and end users in the co-creation of R&I agendas and contents (such as citizen science).

PF: Postdoctoral fellowship

Postdoctoral researcher: applicants must be in a possession of a doctoral degree at the date of the call deadline. Applicants who have successfully defended their doctoral thesis but who have not yet formally been awarded the doctoral degree

will also be considered as postdoctoral researchers and will be considered eligible to apply.

REA: European Research Executive Agency

Research experience: at the call deadline, the researcher must have a maximum of 8 years fulltime equivalent experience in research, measured from the date of award of the doctoral degree. Years of experience outside research and career breaks (e.g. due to parental leave), will not count towards the amount of research experience. For nationals or long-term residents of EU Member States or Horizon Europe Associated Countries who wish to reintegrate to pursue their research career in EU Member States or Horizon Europe Associated Countries, years of experience in research in third countries will not be considered in the above maximum.

Secondment: planned stay of the researcher at an associated partner in any country worldwide during the fellowship with specific supervision arrangements, clear planned training and/or research objectives.

SEP: the EU online tool for remote evaluation.

Technical robustness (Artificial Intelligence): refers to technical aspects of AI systems and development, including resilience to attack and security, fall-back plan and general safety, accuracy, reliability and reproducibility. AI-based systems or techniques should be, or be developed to become technically robust, accurate and reproducible, and able to deal with and inform about possible failures, inaccuracies and errors, proportionate to the assessed risk posed by the AI-based system or technique.

Third Countries (TC): countries that are neither EU Member States (MS), nor associated to Horizon Europe (AC).